Feudal Society in Medieval Europe

After the fall of Rome

After the Western Roman Empire collapsed in the fifth century, Europe lost the central government that had kept roads safe, collected taxes and paid armies. Groups from eastern and central Europe, such as the Franks, Goths and Lombards, settled in France, Spain and Italy. Trade shrank, towns emptied and most people lived in villages that had to protect themselves.

The period from the fifth to the fifteenth century is called the medieval era. Historians such as Marc Bloch, who studied France, argued that to understand it we must look not only at kings and battles but at land, geography and the everyday life of ordinary people.

Lords, vassals and the fief

The word feudal comes from the German word feud, which means a piece of land. A powerful lord gave a fief, a grant of land, to a vassal. In return the vassal swore loyalty, served as a knight in war and gave advice. The lord promised protection and justice. This chain of promises ran from the king down to the smallest knight.

Charlemagne, who ruled the Franks from 768 to 814, used grants of land to bind nobles to him. By the eleventh century this system had spread across much of western and central Europe.

Three orders of society

Medieval writers described society as three orders: the clergy, who prayed; the nobility, who fought; and the peasants, who worked. The Church owned about a third of the land and collected a tithe, one tenth of every harvest. Most peasants were serfs. They could not leave the manor, had to work on the lord's fields three days a week and paid him in grain, eggs and labour.

The manor

A manor was the lord's estate: his house, the village, the fields, a mill, a church and common woods and pastures. Fields were farmed in three strips: one sown in autumn, one in spring and one left empty to rest. This three-field rotation, together with the heavy iron plough, raised harvests after the year 1000, and the population of Europe grew from about 42 million to 73 million by 1300.